“Randy, where is the rest of me?” while I reached with my hands, feeling the covers where my legs should have been.

There was no retake. Sam quietly said: “Print it.” I realized I had passed one of the biggest milestones in my career. I still believe *Kings Row* is the finest picture I ever appeared in and it elevated me to the degree of stardom I had dreamed of when I had arrived in Hollywood four years earlier.

Bob Cummings, my costar, must have wondered in later years whether he might be a psychic of some sort: Clear back then on the set of that movie, Bob had a line that he would always use on me: “Someday,” he said, “I’m going to vote for this fellow for president.”

Kings Row was the only picture I was in for which there was ever any talk of my getting an Academy Award. But that year, Warner Brothers also made *Yankee Doodle Dandy*, with Jimmy Cagney playing George M. Cohan. In those days the studios usually got behind only one picture in the Oscar race, and it picked *Yankee Doodle Dandy*. I’ve certainly never begrudged Jimmy Cagney for that: It was not only a great picture, but he was great in it. This actor, so much identified in people’s minds as a tough guy, had originally begun his career as a dancer and in that picture he was brilliant.

I didn’t get an Oscar, but even before *Kings Row* was released, Warners offered me a seven-year contract at a considerable increase in salary over my existing contract, which only had a couple of years to go. It was an indication big things were expected of *Kings Row* and that after its release I might be in a position to ask for more than they were offering me or sit out the old contract and become a free agent.

Negotiations for my new contract were going on when I received a telephone call from my brother on a Sunday morning telling me that the Japanese had bombed Pearl